wreck of him. I saw him a short time since & very much astonished I was at the very great alteration in his appearance. He is reduced to a perfect skeleton, both hands in flour and water, and legs swathed in flannel and in a very low and desponding condition, totally incapable, I feel assured, of giving any attention to any affair howsoever important. I fear in my humble opinion his constitution is shattered beyond redemption.'[58] Elphinstone had sent the report to Auckland and asked to be relieved of his command; now he was finalising his plans for returning to India, and hence to retirement among his beloved Scottish grouse moors.

As part of the cuts, Macnaghten had also decided to further reduce the small British garrison remaining in Afghanistan and to send back to India 'Fighting Bob' Sale and his brigade. Sale was now instructed to make a detour on his return journey to knock down a few Ghilzai forts and quell any signs of the uprising that he encountered on his way out of the country: the tribes, Macnaghten wrote calmly, 'were very kind in breaking out just at the moment most opportune for our purpose. The troops will take them en route to India.'[59]

When Sale's Orcadian Military Engineer, George Broadfoot, went to see Elphinstone to collect intelligence and finalise the plans to 'chastise' the eastern Ghilzais, he found the General 'in a pitiable state of health, absolutely unfit for duty', and so 'lost and perplexed' he ended up asking himself whether the General was still entirely sane.[60]

> He insisted in getting up and was supported to his visitor's room. This exertion so exhausted him that it was half an hour before he could attend to business, indeed several ineffectual attempts to do so had excited him so much that I was sorry I had come at all . . . He said he did not know the number or strength of the [Ghilzai] forts [and] complained bitterly of the way he was deprived of all authority [by Macnaghten] and reduced to a cipher . . . [Later] I went back to the General and found him in bed and quite worn out . . . He told me once more how he had been tormented by Macnaghten from the first; reduced, to use his own words, from a General to a head constable. He asked me to see him before I moved, but he said, 'if anything occurs, for God sake clear the passes quickly, that I may get away. For, if anything were to turn up I am unfit for it, done up body and mind, and I have told Lord Auckland so.' This he repeated two or three times, adding he doubted very much he would ever see home, even if he did get away.[61]

As he left, Broadfoot told the General about his own anxieties: he had tried to get the smiths and armourers in the city to manufacture some mining tools to be used in the siege of the Ghilzai forts, but they had all 'refused to work for the Firangis as they were busy forging arms, for what purpose we